

PURPOSE: To introduce the option of performing 10 hours of physical wellness and 3 wellness seminars, with two of the three seminars being interchangeable with 1 hour of physical wellness. A minimum of one seminar will still be required to obtain a Satisfactory or an Outstanding grade. This will replace the previous requirement of 15 hours of physical wellness and two seminars per quarter in order to receive an Outstanding grade in Wellness.

INTRODUCED BY: Grace Ann Courtney

BE IT RESOLVED BY THE MISSISSIPPI SCHOOL FOR MATHEMATICS AND SCIENCE

SECTION ONE (REASONING):

Many MSMS students struggle to accomplish the minimum of 15 hours of physical wellness per quarter. Each quarter, students are graded on their ability to perform 15 hours of physical wellness. This grade will later affect their privilege plans which grant certain privileges while attending MSMS. Maintaining physical wellness is an important factor in maintaining overall wellness, but sometimes it is difficult for students to achieve these fifteen hours with the demanding workload that MSMS classes require. These factors include the stress of being an MSMS student, personal or home issues, or general discomfort while exercising. Adopting new policies concerning wellness could benefit the MSMS community and allow students more flexibility in what assignments to prioritize as workload at the end of the quarter increases.

In a Microsoft Form sent out by me, Senator Courtney, 49% of students struggle to get the required 15 hours of wellness per quarter. 48% percent of students feel like struggling to get wellness affects their mental health. When I introduced the idea that wellness seminars should be interchangeable with more hours of physical activity, 86% of students agreed. Furthermore, 73% of students would like to see more seminars and fewer hours of physical activity.

Knowing that wellness is designed to ease students' mental health, the fact that close to 50% of the polled student population feels stressed about getting the required physical hours feels problematic. The stress of not being able to meet the constant requirements put on MSMS students can cause declining mental health and priorities to be underplayed.

In the free-response section of my Microsoft Form, I asked the question, "Do you have any other thoughts about the current wellness system?" Among the 56 responses, these were the most notable:

"I think the interchangeable seminar idea is great! There were definitely times when I was interested in a seminar but didn't go because I had already done two."

"While I'm not having too much difficulty with it, I know of a bunch of people who keep missing the wellness requirements, sometimes because they simply forgot to sign out. A rework of the time counting system could help."

With a decrease in physical hours and an increase in seminars, it could help to better accommodate students who can't find the time to get physical activity. Since two of the three seminars are still interchangeable with physical activity, students who enjoy exercising will still have that option. With the implementation of new policies favoring the mental health of students more yet still paying regard to those who enjoy physical activity, all students will be satisfied, and some unrest will be solved.

Although the majority of the student population supports physical wellness hours being reduced, there are still state requirements in physical exercise that must be met. According to shapeamerica.org, Mississippi's state requirement for graduation is 0.5 Carnegie units of physical exercise. 0.5 Carnegie units is worth 60 hours, but since this provides no time frame and MSMS is a residential school, these hours can be split over the course of two years. This means that by state requirements, students only need 8 hours of physical wellness per quarter. Ten hours of physical wellness hours per quarter add up to 80 hours by graduation, which is well over the 60-hour threshold.

The Centers for Disease Control and Prevention states that mental and physical health are equally important components of overall health. The CDC also states that feelings of loneliness and isolation are factors of mental illness. Wellness seminars promote community and get students out of their dorms, which is the most important. This option will initiate better social lives for students, better mental states, and more productive use of their time with the reduction of wellness hours.

Life as a student at a school as rigorous as MSMS is stressful enough with the in-class courseload. The additional stress that comes from physical wellness requirements raises the question of whether the point of wellness hours has been over-emphasized along the way. This proposal is a happy medium that still requires a certain number of physical hours but includes an appropriate amount of time for relaxation in the form of seminars.

SECTION TWO (SPECIFIC CHANGES):

On Page 53 of the Student Handbook (PDF page 58) under the section "MSMS Non-Academic Requirements for Graduation," the following would be changed to:

Wellness

The MSMS Wellness Program requires each student to participate in a minimum number of physical activity hours and minimum attendance in wellness seminars as directed by the coordinator for this program and explained during orientation. **Students are given the option to perform either a minimum of 12 hours of physical activity and 1 wellness seminar, 11 hours of physical activity and 2 wellness seminars, or 10 hours of physical activity and 3 wellness seminars in order to obtain an Outstanding (O) grade. 10 hours of physical activity and 1 wellness seminar, 9 hours of physical activity and 2 wellness seminars, and 8 hours of physical activity and 3 wellness seminars will earn the student a Satisfactory (S) grade. Any combination**

of physical activity and seminars below these guidelines will cause the student to receive an Unsatisfactory (U) grade for the quarter.